

Article

Morphosyntactic Marking of Focus: Subject–Object Asymmetries in Bantu

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Abstract

In many African languages, there exists a type of subject–object asymmetry by which subject focus must be expressed by A-bar movement to a morphologically marked left peripheral position whereas object focalisation can be expressed by movement and morphological marking in the left periphery, or in situ. In this article, we discuss and analyse this structural asymmetry in the Bantu languages Basaá and Mmaala. We argue that overt and covert movement of the focused object to Spec-FocP in the left periphery is allowed while covert movement of the subject is blocked, so that overt movement is the only possible option. Contrary to previous analyses, which attribute the obligatoriness of subject focus movement and marking to an interpretive conflict, we propose a formal characterisation of this phenomenon by which the blocking of subject focalisation in situ is deduced from criterial freezing, so that overt movement to the left periphery is the only option, through a familiar strategy of overt subject extraction.

Keywords: Bantu; criterial freezing; focus; subject object asymmetries

1. Introduction¹

The question as to why subject focus cannot be expressed in situ in the canonical subject position in many African languages has raised much attention from various viewpoints in the literature. The prevailing claim is that preverbal subjects in those languages have topic-like properties (see Bresnan & Kanerva, 1989; Morimoto, 2000; Henderson, 2006; Zeller, 2008; on Southern Bantu and Fiedler et al., 2010 on Chadic, Kru and Kwa), in line with Givón (1976). According to this view, the subject must be ‘detopicalised’ in order to allow a narrow focal interpretation. This is generally obtained in two ways: Either the subject is placed postverbally, or it is moved to the left periphery. Alternative views have been put forth on the exact nature of the interpretive properties of subjects (e.g., Zerbian, 2006; Cheng & Downing, 2014), which share with the previously mentioned approaches the idea that the obligatory marking of subject focus is fundamentally due to an interpretive clash that would otherwise arise. In short, all these claims try to deduce the subject/object asymmetry from interpretative effects. In this paper, we explore a type of subject–object asymmetry that occurs in focus constructions in the Bantu languages Basaá and Mmaala. Like in many other Bantu languages, subject focus involves obligatory movement in overt syntax to a dedicated position in the left periphery, a position marked by special focus morphology, whereas object focus can be expressed by overt movement with morphological



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marking, or in situ. We show that this asymmetry in focalisation is not attributed to an interpretative conflict but is a consequence of criterial freezing (Rizzi, 2006, 2021). The paper is organised as follows: Section 1 provides background information about Basáa and Mmaala. Section 2 is concerned with subject and object focus marking. Section 3 deals with the syntactic analysis of the phenomena under discussion.

2. Background

Basáa (basáa) and Mmaala are tone² languages that belong to the Narrow Bantu group. They are spoken in Cameroon and display a basic SVO order like in (1) and (2).

- (1) **málêt** a-n-sómb βíkaat Basáa
1teacher 1SM-PST1-buy 8books
'The teacher bought the books.'
- (2) **agánd** gɔ-gu-ɔn ɪnɔk Mmaala
CL.WOMAN FUT1-INF-KILL snake
'The woman will kill a snake.'

In double object constructions, the indirect object precedes the direct object, and the reverse order is disallowed.

- (3) **málêt** a-n-tí (*bikaat) ɓáúdú βíkaat Basáa
1teacher 1SM-PST1-give 8books 2students 8books
'The teacher gave the books to the students.'
- (4) **agánd** gɔ-gu-fa (*manan) baabajɔ manan Mmaala
CL.WOMAN FUT1-INF-give food CL.children CL.food
'The woman will give the food to the children.'

In both languages, the direct object > indirect object order is allowed if the former is pronominalised. This occurs when the direct object represents old information whereas the indirect object is new in the discourse. This is illustrated in the question–answer pairs in (5) and (6).

- (5) A. ndʒéé ɓáúdú ɓá-n-tí **mákebla** Basáa
1who 1teacher 2SM-PST1-give 6presents
'Who did the students give the presents to?'
- B. ɓáúdú ɓá-n-tí **mó** malêt (*mó)
1teacher 1SM-PST1-give 6them 1teacher 6them
'The students gave them to the TEACHER.'
- (6) A. **apa** agánd gɔ-gu-nu-fa manjan Mmaala
who woman FUT1-INF-PRT-give food
'Who will the woman give the food to?'
- B. agánd gɔ-gu-nu-fa **mó** baabajɔ (*mó)
CL.WOMAN FUT1-INF-give CL.it CL.children CL.it
'The woman will give it to the children.'

Basáa and Mmaala are noun class languages. As is the case in many languages, nouns are classified according to classes. Noun classes are indicated by specific prefixes. Basáa involves twelve distinct nominal classes, which vary in number and person. At this point

of the study, we are not aware of any work on the noun class system on Mmaala. We refrain from using cardinal numbers for the glossing of the noun classes in this language. Based on its rich morphological agreement displayed in the nominal system common to Bantu languages, we assume that we are dealing with a noun class language akin to many other noun class languages. The following nominal constructions in (7) and (8) delineate morphological agreement between the head noun and its dependents.

- (7) a. **íní** **tâmb** **jêm** **ikéńí** **ilâm** Basaá
7DEM.PROX 7shoe 7POSS.3PL 7big 7nice
 ‘This nice (as opposed to *that*) big shoe of mine.’
- b. **βíní** **βítâmb** **gwêm** **βíkéńí** **βilâm**
8DEM.PROX 8shoes 8POSS.1SG 8big 8nice
 ‘These (as opposed to *those*) nice big shoes of mine.’
- (8) a. **gibógɔd** **gjam** **gibólotot** **egje,** Mmaala
CL.shoe CL.POSS.1SG CL.red DEM.PROX.CL
 ‘This red shoe of mine.’
- b. **bibógɔd** **bjam** **bitatɔ** **bibólotot** **ebje**
CL.shoes CL.POSS.1SG CL.three CL.red DEM.PROX.CL
 ‘These three red shoes of mine.’

Morphological agreement in the noun phrase is controlled by the head noun, the morphological features of which are shared by its dependents. Basaá and Mmaala also differ with respect to the structural position of negation and subject–verb agreement.

- (9) a. **málêt** **a-bí-tí** **ǂê** **6áúdu** **bikaat** Basaá
1teacher 1SM-PST2-give NEG 2students 8books
 ‘The teacher did not give the books to the students.’
- b. **agánd** **ǂi-ga-gu-fa** **baabajɔ** **manjan** Mmaala
CL.WOMAN NEG-FUT1-INF-give CL.children CL.food
 ‘The woman will not give the food to the children.’

Basaá (9a) has low negation that occurs after the verb whereas negation is higher in Mmaala (9b). Negation precedes the verb and all the elements that make up the verbal complex. Another structural difference between both languages is the null subject phenomenon (Rizzi, 1982). Despite the fact that Mmaala displays morphological agreement within the noun phrase (8), it is characterised by the absence of morphological subject–verb agreement and does not allow null subjects (11). Unlike Mmaala, Basaá (10) displays morphological subject–verb agreement and allows null subjects like many other Bantu languages.³

- (10) a. **málêt** **a-bí-tí** **6áúdu** **bikaat**
1teacher 1SM-PST2-give 2students 8books
 ‘The teacher gave the students the books.’
- b. **a-bí-tí** **ǂɔ** **bí-kaat**
1SM-PST2-give 2them 8-books
 ‘S/he (the teacher) gave them the books.’

- (11) a. **agánd** ga-gu-fa baabajɔ mapan
 CL.WOMAN FUT1-INF-give CL.children CL.food
 ‘The woman will give the children the food.’
- b. *ga-gu-fa bɔ́ mapan
 FUT-INF-give 2them CL.food

Just like in other languages that delineate morphological subject–verb agreement, null subjects in Basaá are licensed by the subject marker (SM) that bears the noun class features of the subject, also encoding person and number specifications. The presence of morphological agreement inside the nominal layer and its absence at the clausal level in Mmaala make it different from Basaá and other noun class Bantu languages such as Tuki (Bilola, 2013), Kinande (Baker, 2008), Makhuwa-Enahara (Van der Wal, 2009), Sambia (Riedel, 2009), and Zulu (Zeller, 2008; Halpert, 2015) in which morphological agreement occurs both within the nominal and clausal layers, supporting the view that DP-internal agreement and subject–verb agreement are different morphosyntactic phenomena involving distinct mechanisms (see Moscati & Rizzi, 2014, based on acquisition data). In comparison with Mmaala, Basaá is relatively well described in the literature. Some works include grammatical studies such as Rosenhuber (1908); Schürle (1912); Voorhoeve (1980); Dimmendaal (1988); Bitjaa Kody (2017), etc. Some well-known works in linguistics include Bôt Ba Njock (1962, 1970), Bitjaa Kody (1990), Mbom (1990), Schmidt (1994, 1996), Ngo Nd-jeyiha (1996, 2005), Mutaka and Bitjaa Kody (2000), Hyman (2003), Makasso (2008, 2023), Bassong (2014, 2019, 2021), Hamlaoui and Makasso (2015), Makasso and Lee (2015), etc. Coded A.62B by Maho (2009), the Mmaala language has been studied by Ossoko (2017, 2019, 2023) on pragmatics.

2.1. Focus Marking

This section discusses subject and non-subject focalisation in the two languages. Like in many African languages, there is a salient structural asymmetry between subject and non-subject focus marking. See also (F. Schwarz, 2003, 2007; Bassong, 2014 for other Bantu, Zimmermann, 2006; Hartmann & Zimmermann, 2007 for A. Schwarz & Fiedler, 2007; Fiedler et al., 2010 for Chadic, Kwa and Gur). We confine ourselves to subject and object focalisation as focalisation of adjuncts, as well as of indirect objects, is analogous to that of objects. While subject focus involves overt movement to the left periphery, to a position signalled by a dedicated focus marker in Basaá and Mmaala, object focus admits both movement to the left periphery and the in situ strategy, by which the focused constituent occurs postverbally and is not morphologically marked in both languages.

2.2. Subject Focus Marking

Although subject focalisation has to always occur ex situ, each language uses a specific focus marking strategy. Subject focus can encode new and contrastive information as discussed in the following sections.

2.2.1. Information Focus

Starting from the basic order in (12), and using the question–answer congruence as a test for focushood, it can be observed in (13)B that the focalised subject *malét* ‘teacher’ in Basaá needs to be moved and focus marked. As is generally the case when focus is expressed by movement, the subject is followed by the focus marker *-n*, which adjoins to the corresponding agreement morpheme *ɲé-* giving rise to the composite form *ɲé-n*. More precisely, the morpheme *ɲé-* bears the gender (noun class 1) and number (singular) specification of the subject. The unacceptability of (13)B indicates that a focalised subject cannot

be left in situ, hence the simple canonical SVO order is infelicitous⁴ as a reply to a subject *wh*-question that requires narrow focus on the subject.

- (12) malêṭ a-n-tíl-á ↓βíkaat Basaá
 1teacher 1SM-PST1-Write-FV 8.books
 ‘The teacher wrote the books.’
- (13) A. ndʒéé a-n-tíl-á ↓βíkaat Basaá
 1who 1SM-PST1-Write-FV 8.books
 ‘Who wrote the books?’
- B. malêṭ_i jé-n t_i a-n-tíl-á ↓βíkaat
 1teacher 1-FOC 1SM-PST1-Write-FV 8.books
 ‘The TEACHER wrote the books.’
- C. #malêṭ a-n-tíl-á ↓βíkaat
 1teacher 1SM-PST1-Write-FV 8.books
 ‘The TEACHER wrote the books.’

Unlike in languages like Gungbe (Aboh, 2004), Kikuyu (F. Schwarz, 2007) and Tuki (Bilola, 2013), question words (*wh*-phrases) in Basaá cannot occur with overt focus morphology (13)A, whereas the corresponding focused constituent in the answer does (13)B. Clearly, a low-level parameter is involved here (does *wh*- co-occur with an overt focus marker? Tuki: yes; Basaá: no).

Compared to Basaá, Mmaala does not have morphological focus markers. Nevertheless, the focusing of a subject in this language is expressed

- A. By the use of a resumptive pronoun in subject position;
- B. By a morphological change in the verbal complex (addition of a particle, a reflex of A-bar extraction);
- C. By the optional addition of a cleft-like structure (it is...) at the beginning of the clause

These three changes are found both in the question (15)A and in the answer (15)B, which are derived from the basic order in (14).

- (14) endimen am gó-gú-ôn ɪɲɔk Mmaala
 brother 1SG.POSS FUT1-INF-kill CL.snake
 ‘My brother will kill a snake.’
- (15) A. (bu ɲɛ) aɲà u_i Mmaala
 EXPL be who 3SG
 gó-gú-nú-ôn ɪɲɔk
 FUT1-INF-PRT-kill CL.snake
 ‘Who will kill a snake?’
- B. (bu ɲɛ) endimen_i am Mmaala
 EXPL be brother 1SG.POSS
 u_i gó-gú-nú-ôn jé / ɪɲɔk
 3.SG FUT1-INF-PRT-kill 3SG CL.snake
 ‘It is my brother who will kill a snake/my brother will kill it (a snake).’
- C. #endimen am gó-gú-ôn jé / ɪɲɔk Mmaala
 brother 1SG.POSS FUT1-INF-kill 3SG CL.snake
 ‘My brother will kill it (a snake).’

B.	äko	(bu	ne)	endimen	am _i
	no	EXPL	be	Brother	1SG.POSS
	u _i	gó-gú-nú-ôn	ne /	ipok	
	3.SG	FUT1-INF-PRT-kill	3SG	CL.snake	
	'No. It is my brother who will kill it/a snake/No. MY BROTHER (not a girl) will kill it/a snake.'				

In (16) and (17), contrastive/corrective focus is expressed by the mention of explicit sets of comparable alternatives in the discourse. Summarising, the earmark of subject focalisation, be it in new information or contrastive contexts, is that it always involves movement and is marked morpho-syntactically in different ways in the two languages. The focalised subject needs to occur *ex situ* and by the use of a focus marker in Basaá. In Mmaala, it is signalled by subject resumption and the morphological change in the verbal complex signalling extractions. This brings up the question as to why subject focus marking is obligatory in Basaá and Mmaala like in many other African languages. The answer to this question is given to Section 3.

2.3. Object Focus Marking

Unlike subject focalisation that has to be marked morphosyntactically, object focus can be expressed *in situ* without any grammatical encoding. This is possible in information and contrastive focus situations in both languages. Examples (18) and (19) illustrate both situations in Basaá while (20) and (21) are instances of new information and contrastive focus in Mmaala.

- (18) A. **Kíí** mudaá a-ń-lâmb Basaá
 10what 1woman 1SM-PRS-COOK
 'What is the woman cooking?'
 B. (mudaá) a-ń-lâmb **tfóβī**
 1woman 1SM-PRS-COOK 13fish
 '(The woman) she is cooking FISH.'
- (19) A. í m'-pooná lé mudaá a-n-lâmb **kóp** Basaá
 EXPL PRS-seem that 1woman 1SM-PST1-COOK 9chicken
 'It seems that the woman cooked chicken.'
 B. h'ééní. mudaá a-n-lâmb **tfóβī**
 no 1woman 1SM-PST1-COOK 13fish
 'No. (The woman) she cooked FISH (not chicken).'
- (20) A. **giàg** Ambassa gó-gú-nú-ôn Mmaala
 what Ambassa FUT1-INF-PRT-kill
 'What will Ambassa kill?'
 B. Ambassa / u gó-gú-ôn **ipok**
 Ambassa 3SG FUT1-INF-kill snake
 'Ambassa/he will kill a snake.'
- (21) A. Ambassa o gu-ôn **mbwa** á Mmaala
 Ambassa CJ PST3-kill dog QM
 'Did Ambassa killed a dog?'
 B. (äko). Ambassa u o gu-ôn **ipok**
 no Ambassa 3SG CJ PST3-INF-kill snake
 'No. Ambassa/he killed a SNAKE (not a dog).'

Object focus can also be expressed by fronting the object to the left periphery. Like subject focus, left peripheral focalisation of the object in Basaá requires morphological focus marking on the object. This strategy is felicitous in information and contrastive focus contexts as shown in (22) and (23), respectively. The fronted objects agree in noun class with the focus marker.

- (22) A. **Kíí** maangé a-ń-dzowa Basaá
 9what 1child 1SM-PRS-wash
 ‘What is the child washing/What does the child wash?’
 B. **mambót mǒ-n** (maangé) a-n-dzowa
 6clothes 6-FOC 1child 1SM-PRS-wash
 ‘The child/he is washing the CLOTHES.’
- (23) A. maangé a-ń-dzowa **mambót** ε Basaá
 1child 1SM-PRS-wash 6clothes QM
 ‘The child is washing/washes the clothes.’
 B. tǒ. **bitám** **gwǒ-n** (maangé) a-ń-dzowa
 no 8shoes 8-FOC 1child 1SM-PRS-wash
 ‘No. The child is washing the SHOES.’

Like subject focalisation, object focalisation through movement to the left periphery may or may not involve a cleft structure and triggers a morphological change in the verbal complex in Mmaala. However, unlike subject focalisation, ex situ focalisation of the object does not trigger resumption at the base as shown in (24) and (25). The particles *ná* in (24) and *nú* (25)B are reflexes of A-bar movement in the “past tense three” form (“yesterday’s past”) and the future tense, respectively.

- (24) A. **giàg** Ambassa *ná*-gu-ôn Mmaala
 what Ambassa PRT-PST3-kill
 ‘What did Ambassa kill?’
 B. (bu *ɲɛ*) **ipɔk** Ambassa / u *ná*-gu-ôn (*jɛ)
 EXPL be CL.Snake Ambassa 3SG prt-pst3-KILL it
 ‘Ambassa (he) killed a SNAKE.’
- (25) A. in gú-bidaga kaa Ambassa Mmaala
 1SG PRS-think that Ambassa
 gó-gú-ôn **mbwa**
 FUT-INF-kill dog
 ‘I think that Ambassa (he) killed a dog.’
 B. (ǎkó) (bu *ɲɛ*) **ipɔk**
 no EXPL be CL.Snake
 Ambassa / u gó-gú-**nú**-ôn (*jɛ)
 Ambassa 3SG FUT1-INF-PRT-kill it
 ‘(No), Ambassa (he) will kill a SNAKE (not a dog).’

In comparison with (13)–(15), the preceding examples in (18)–(24) show the structural asymmetry between the subject and object with respect to focus realisation. This subject–object asymmetry observed cross-linguistically in many African languages has not yet received a consensual analysis. There are divergent views with respect to the main motivations for the obligatoriness of subject focus marking in many languages. Works such as Bresnan and Kanerva (1989), Morimoto (2000), Henderson (2006), and Zeller (2008) on

Southern Bantu languages and Fiedler et al. (2010) on Chadic, Kru and Kwa languages suggest that subject focus marking simply follows from Givón's (1976) generalisation that preverbal subjects have topic-like properties, an idea which is also in line with Li and Thompson (1976)'s view that subjects and topics share some common properties. The aboutness property (Li & Thompson, 1976; Rizzi, 2005; Belletti & Rizzi, 2017), one of such salient features, has been used by some Africanists as evidence that subject focus marking is a detopicalisation strategy. In other words, according to this approach, the position of the lexical subject in the SVO order is topical. In order to achieve a narrow focal interpretation, the subject must be "detopicalised" through overt focus marking.

This analysis has the appeal of simplicity. Nevertheless, we believe there is evidence against it. Whereas there is a tendency to associate subjecthood and topicality, it is not the case that the subject position is necessarily interpreted as topical. For instance, indefinite elements like *someone*, *something*, etc. (see Rizzi, 1997; Frascarelli, 2000; Belletti & Rizzi, 2017 for Italian; Zerbán, 2006 for Northern Sotho; Van der Wal, 2009 for Makhuwa-Enahara; Halpert, 2012 for Zulu; Cheng & Downing, 2014 for Zulu) are not natural topics, but can occur in the preverbal subject position. This can be observed in Basaá (26) and Mmaala (27), where the indefinite quantifiers *ngim mut* and *mɔ̀nd*, the English equivalents for 'someone', function as lexical subjects.

(26) **ngim** **mut** i-bí-sómb-ól ɓóóŋgé bitámb Basaá
 1INDF 1person 9SM-PST2-buy-APPL 2children shoes
 'Someone bought the shoes for the children.'

(27) **mɔ̀nd** sa-fa babàjɔ m̀nán Mmaala
 someone PST2-give children food
 'Someone gave the food to the children.'

Moreover, inherently non-topical elements like *ngim mut* and *mɔ̀nd* 'someone', if focalised, require overt movement and cannot be focalised 'in situ' in the canonical subject position. This is shown in (28) for Basaá and (29) for Mmaala. The absence of subject movement in subject focus contexts yields an infelicitous interpretation as indicated in the C's replies.

(28) A. **ndʒéé** a-bí-sómb-ól ɓóóŋgé bitámb Basaá
 1who 1SM-PST2-buy-APPL 2children shoes
 'Who bought the shoes for the children.'

B. **ngim** **mut** **jɔ́-n** i-bí-sómb-ól ɓó gw̃
 1INDF 1person 9-FOC 9SM-PST2-buy-APPL 2them 8them
 'Someone bought them for them.'

C. **#ngim** **mut** i-bí-sómb-ól ɓó gw̃
 1INDF 1person 9SM-PST2-buy-APPL 2them 8them
 'Someone bought them for them.'

(29) A. (bu jɛ) **ɔ́nɔ́** **u** sa-gu-fa babàjɔ m̀nán Mmaala
 EXPL be who 3SG PST2-PRT-give children food
 'Who gave food to the children?'

B.	(bu jɛ)	mɔ̀nd _i	u _i	sa-gu-fa	bɔ́j	mɔ́k
	EXPL be	person	3SG	PST2-PRT-give	3PL	3PL
	'SOMEONE gave it to them.'					
C.	#mɔ̀nd	sa-fa		bɔ́j	mɔ́k	
	person	PST2-1SG-give		3PL	3SG	
	'Someone gave it to me.' ²					

Examples (28)B and (29)B attest that an interpretive conflict approach to (13)C and (15)D is not adequate as existential quantifiers that are not natural topics also have to be focus marked *ex situ*. Thus, the subject position in the canonical SVO order cannot be assumed to obligatorily trigger topic information. Put another way, the obligatoriness of subject focus movement and marking cannot be analysed as an interpretative conflict resolution strategy.

3. Criterial Freezing and the Subject-Criterion

In this section, we show how the obligatory *ex situ* focalisation of subjects can be captured in formal terms. More precisely, we show that criterial freezing is the main source of this phenomenon in these languages, and probably in many other African languages from various groups such as Bantu (see [Zerbian, 2006](#) for Nothern Sotho; [Van der Wal, 2009](#) for Makhuwa-Enahara; [Halpert, 2012](#) for Zulu; [Cheng & Downing, 2014](#) for Zulu, etc.), Chadic, Kwa and Gur (see [Fiedler et al., 2010](#) for a cross-linguistic study, but see also [Hartmann & Zimmermann, 2007](#) for Hausa), which exhibit similar subject–object asymmetries in focalisation. In line with the criterial approach to scope discourse semantics, chain formation in syntax ([Rizzi, 2006, 2017](#); [Rizzi & Shlonsky, 2007](#); [Shlonsky, 2014](#); [Shlonsky & Rizzi, 2018](#); [Roy & Shlonsky, 2019](#), etc.) is sensitive to structural configurations so much so that phrasal categories moved to the specifier positions of criterial heads are frozen in place and become unavailable to further movement, along the lines of the principle in (30).

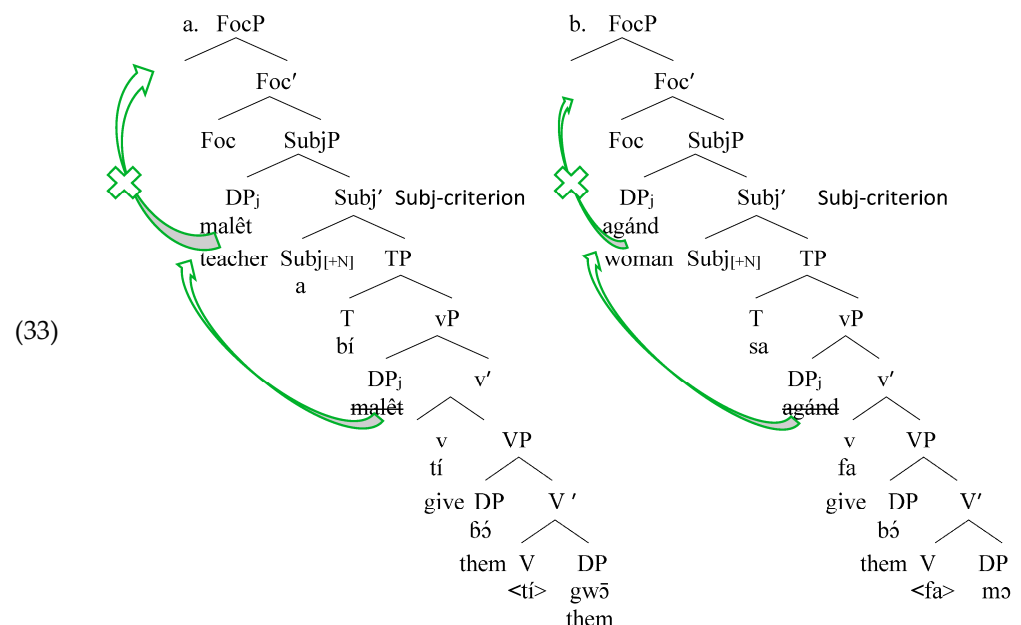
- (30) Criterial Freezing: In a criterial configuration, the criterial goal is frozen in place. ([Rizzi, 2021](#), p. 275).

Starting from [Rizzi \(2006\)](#), the principle in (30) guarantees the mapping between a phrasal category, a given syntactic configuration and a specific interpretative property. As such, the driving force of a criterial head is that once a given phrase with matching features is attracted to its specifier position, that phrase gets frozen and becomes unavailable for further syntactic operations.⁷ At the interfaces with sound and meaning, this criterial head guides the interpretative properties of its specifier and complement and yields configurations such as Topic–Comment, Focus–Presupposition, etc. Criterial freezing is not only concerned with phrasal categories moving to scope taking positions in the left periphery. It also deals with phrases targeting A-positions such as the subject position. In this section, the analysis is confined to subject and focus positions. [Rizzi \(2006\)](#) suggests that the subject position is criterial following the cartography of subject positions ([Cardinaletti, 2004](#)). According to him, there is a formal Subj(ect) head in the clausal spine. This Subj head is merged above the T head. It attracts the closest nominal element to its Spec and, at LF, it determines the “aboutness” property: the complement of Subj, the predicate, is going to be interpreted as being “about” the specifier. Being a criterial position, when the lexical subject is moved to Spec-SubjP it undergoes freezing effects as a consequence of (30).

Consider now the impossibility of focalisation *in situ* of the subject, illustrated by the C answers in (31) and (32).

- (31) A. **ndʒéé** a-bí-tī- 6óóŋgé bikaat Basaá
 1who 1SM-PST2-give 2children 8books
 ‘Who gave the books to the children?’
- B. **malét** **ɲé-n** a-bí-tī- 6ó gwɔ̃
 1teacher 1-FOC 1SM-PST2-give 2them 8them
 ‘The TEACHER gave them to them.’
- C. **#malét** a-bí-tī- 6ó gwɔ̃
 1teacher 1SM-PST2-give 2them 8them
 ‘The teacher gave them to them.’
- (32) A. (bu ɲɛ) **apa_i** **u_i** sa-gu-fa babàjɔ; màɲán_k Mmaala
 EXPL be who 3SG PST2-PRT-give children food
 ‘Who gave food to the children?’
- B. (bu ɲɛ) **agánd_i** **u_i** sa-gu-fa bój mɔ_k
 EXPL be woman 3SG PST2-PRT-give 3PL 3PL
 ‘The woman gave it to them.’
- C. **#agánd** sa-fa bój mɔ_k
 woman PST2-1SG-give 3PL 3SG
 ‘The woman gave it to me.’

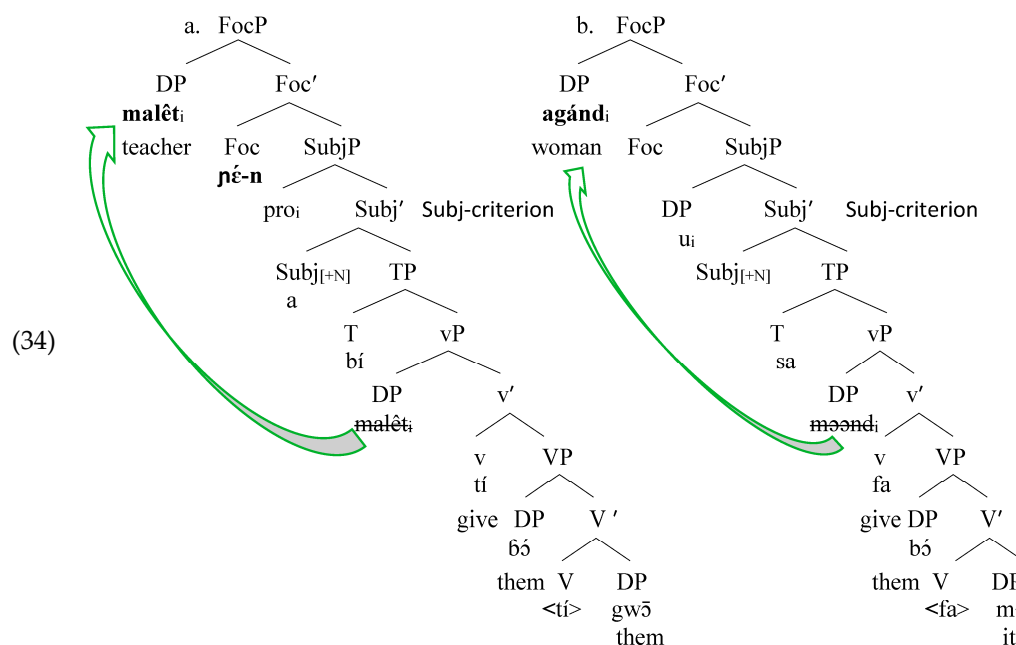
Assuming that ‘in situ’ focalisation involves covert focus movement (Chomsky, 1977), and that covert as much as overt focus movement targets a dedicated Spec-FocP in the left periphery (Rizzi, 1997), this covert movement cannot occur from a subject position, which, following the literature quoted above, we assume to be criterial. Thus, the unacceptability of (31)C and (32)C derived in (33a) and (33b) arises from the fact that covert subject movement to Spec-FocP is blocked by criterial freezing in Spec-SubjP as depicted in (33).



Why is it that, if covert subject movement to focus is excluded by freezing, overt subject movement is fine? It is well-known that natural languages can use a variety of strategies to overtly move subjects and circumvent freezing effects (Rizzi & Shlonsky, 2007). One classical strategy generally available to Null Subject Languages consists of satisfying the Subject Criterion (or, in GB terms, the Extended Projection Principle) through non-

referential *pro*, and moving the thematic subject from a lower position (Rizzi, 1982). As Basaá is a null subject language, we expect this strategy to be available. So, in (34a) the subject-criterion may be satisfied by *pro* in Spec-SubjP, and the thematic subject may be moved directly from the thematic position to the Spec-Foc position.⁸

On the contrary, Mmaala is not a Null Subject Language: it lacks morphological subject–verb agreement, hence, in accordance with Taraldsen’s generalisation, it does not license subject *pro*. All other things being equal between the two languages, we expect Mmaala to permit overt subject focalisation but with the use of an overt resumptive pronoun, *pro* being unavailable. The expectation is correct, as is shown by the acceptability of (32b). Under the set of assumptions we are adopting, this sentence is derived as indicated in (34b), with Spec-SubjP filled by an overt pronoun.⁹ The lexical subject in both languages takes off directly from Spec-vP, its first merge site on its way to Spec-FocP (or through the alternative derivational steps mentioned in fn 7). In Basaá (34a), the focus head is filled by the focus marker *né-n*, which values its features with those of the focalised subject *malét* ‘teacher’ in Spec-FocP. Again, it is assumed that Mmaala uses an unpronounced focus marker akin to Italian-type languages (Rizzi, 1997) whose focus markers are implicit.



This analysis straightforwardly captures the subject–object asymmetry. In situ focalised objects as described in (18)–(21) are allowed because there is no object-criterion, hence no freezing effect. More precisely, in cases like (18)–(21), covert object focus movement on the LF side is allowed because nothing blocks the object from moving.¹⁰ Alongside in situ focalisation (hence covert movement to FocP), overt object movement to focus is an alternative option: both are consistent with the operative principles and lead to well-formedness. In partial conclusion, the obligatoriness of subject focus marking in Basaá and Mmaala can be traced back to a formal explanation, namely criterial freezing. Freezing effects block covert movement of the lexical subject to Spec-FocP in canonical SVO structures. To circumvent these effects and satisfy both the subject and focus criteria, each criterion has to be satisfied independently. The subject-criterion is satisfied by a resumptive subject pronoun in Spec-SubjP, null or overt depending on whether a language allows null subjects or not. In so doing, the subject moves directly from its Spec-vP to the focus

field (or is remnant-moved, in the derivation suggested in fn 7) where it can satisfy the focus-criterion successfully.

4. Conclusions

The structural asymmetry observed in subject and object focalisation in the Bantu languages Basaá and Mmaala is also attested in many other African languages. In this paper we have argued against an analysis based on an interpretive conflict between subjects and topics. We have proposed an alternative by which the obligatoriness of subject focus marking is deduced from Criterial Freezing. Covert movement from a subject position is excluded as a freezing effect, whereas covert object movement is unimpeded, as there is no object criterion. Overt movement to Spec-Foc of a subject is made possible by a familiar rescue strategy, the satisfaction of the Subject Criterion by a pronoun, a strategy immediately visible in the non-Null Subject Language Mmaala. This class of subject–object asymmetries in focalisation strategy is thus reduced to the larger family of the subject–object asymmetries of the *that*-trace type.

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Data Availability Statement: The data supporting the research findings reported in this paper are based on the first and second authors' grammaticality judgements as native speakers of Basaá and Mmaala respectively. An informal survey was also conducted with six native speakers of Basaá to judge the subject-object asymmetry observed in focus marking.

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Notes

- ¹ The abbreviations used in this study are based on the Leipzig Glossing Rules system including cases where additional abbreviations are added. Cardinal numbers associated with nouns and noun dependents signal noun classes in Basaá. Numaala is another spelling for Mmaala.
₁ = first person; ₂ = second person; ₃ = third person; ACC = accusative; AGR = agreement; APPL = applicative; ASP = aspect; AUX = auxiliary; BEN = benefactive; CJ = conjoint; CL = class; CONN = connective; DEF = definiteness marker; DEM = demonstrative; DIST = distal; EXPL = expletive; FOC = focus marker; FUT₁ = future tense one; FUT₂ = future tense two; FV = final vowel; INF = infinitive; INDF = indefinite; LOC = locative; NEG = negation; PL = plural; PRS = present; PRT = particle; PST₁ = past tense one; PST₂ = past tense two; PST₃ = past tense three; PST₄ = past tense four; POSS = possessive; PROG = progressive; PROX = proximal; PRT = particle; SG = singular; SM = subject marker; QM = question marker; SUBJ = subject.
- ² We intentionally leave the low tone unmarked and consider that a toneless nasal or vowel sound bears a low tone. As tone is not relevant for this study, only the high [´], falling [ˋ], and rising [ˊ] tones are marked.
- ³ The two languages therefore behave in accordance with “Taraldsen’s generalisation” (Taraldsen, 1980), which shows here its relevance outside the Indo-European family.
- ⁴ This runs counter to Hamlaoui and Makasso (2015)’s view that subject focus in Basaá is unmarked when it encodes new information (see Bassong, 2014 for the opposing view). Consider the following example from Hamlaoui and Makasso (2015, p. 41). We adopt the glossing system as used in the original work.

- (i) A. N-dʒé à-ñ-níp ñhóólàk lí-kòndò?
 1-who 1.AGR-PST1-steal 3-ripe 3.CONN.5-plantain
 ‘Who stole the ripe plantain?’
 B. m-ààngé à-ñ-níp ñhóólàk lí-kòndò
 1-child 1.AGR-PST1-steal 3-ripe 3.CONN.5-plantain
 ‘THE CHILD stole the ripe plantain.’

For Bassong (native speaker of Basaá), (iB) is infelicitous as an answer to the question in (iA). However, it is perfectly acceptable and appropriate in a context in which the subject is given information, i.e., as an answer to questions like ‘What about the child?’ or ‘What did the child do?’ Or as an answer to a question like ‘What happened?’, in which the subject is part of an all-new sentence.

In order to corroborate this judgment, we conducted an informal survey with six native speakers of Basaá.

The informal survey fully confirmed the subject–object asymmetry. In context (iiA), requiring narrow focus on the subject, all our informants required overt focus marking on the subject, as in (iiB), and found the lack of marking in (iiC) infelicitous.

- (ii) A. mɛ bí-téédá kógā jɛm jaaní. Mɛ ń-jí ɓéé ndʒéé
 1sg PST2-keep 7cake 7my 1yesterday 1sg PRS-know NEG 1who
 a-n-dʒé jɔ
 1SM-PRS-eat 7it
 ‘I kept my cake yesterday. I don’t know who ate it.’
 B. ok. Konde jé-n a-n-dʒé jɔ
 1Konde 1FOC 1SM-PRS-eat 7it
 ‘KONDE ate it.’
 C. # Konde a-n-dʒé jɔ
 1Konde 1SM-PRS-eat 7it
 ‘Konde ate it.’

In contrast, for all the six informants a context requiring narrow focus on the object like (iiiA) permitted both focalisation in situ (as in (iiiB)) and movement of the object to the left periphery with overt focus marking, as in (iiiC)):

- (iii) A. mudaá a-n-tí liwándá dʒɛm ɲgim jɔm. ndí mɛ n-téhé ɓéé jɔ
 1woman 1SM-PST1-give 5friend 5my 9some 9thing but 1sg PST1-see NEG 9it
 ‘The woman gave something to my friend. But I didn’t see it.’
 B. ok. (mudaá) a-n-tí jé ɓikaat
 1woman 1SM-PST1-give 3sg 8books
 ‘The woman/she gave him/her the BOOKS.’
 C. ok. ɓikaat gwó-n (mudaá) a-n-tí jé
 8books 8-FOC 1woman 1SM-PST1-give 3sg
 ‘The woman/she gave him/her the BOOKS.’

The contrast (iiC)–(iiiC) thus confirms the subject–object asymmetry.

⁵ A full analysis of the structural position of the morpheme *nú* and related particles in this language goes beyond the scope of this paper. We hope to address this specific phenomenon in future research.

⁶ The question markers (QM) are used only in yes/no questions (see Bassong, 2014 for their pragmatic functions).

⁷ See Rizzi (2017) for an attempt to derive Criterial Freezing from Chomsky’s (2013) labelling algorithm and a principle of maximality.

⁸ Alternatively, a “big DP” including the lexical subject and *pro* is moved to Spec-Subj, and then the lexical subject is subextracted to Spec-Foc (along the lines proposed in Bassong et al., 2025 for other cases in Basaá). In this alternative, *pro* satisfies the Subject Criterion and allows the lexical subject to be subextracted without violating freezing. We gloss over the distinction between “expletive *pro*”, as in Rizzi (1982), and “resumptive *pro*” as in the approach mentioned in this footnote. The two approaches differ in derivational details, but crucially have in common the use of a non-referential occurrence of *pro*. In Mmaala the ‘big DP’ including the lexical subject and the resumptive pronoun initially merged in Spec, vP is attracted to Spec, Subj followed by subextraction of the lexical subject to Spec, Foc. An anonymous reviewer raises the question why no cross-over effect is found in structures like (34). Following standard practice, we assume cross-over effects do not arise when the pronoun, the operator and the variable belong to the same representational chain. It is only when the pronoun has an independent theta role with respect to the operator–variable chain that such effects arise.

- ⁹ Subject focus in Mmaala is sensitive to island effects, indicating that the focalised subject is not base-generated in the left periphery: (i) instantiates the adjunct island and (ii) illustrates the complex noun phrase island.

- (i) a. ɔ gu-ɔbɔn bese $[\text{gagualga}$ agánd m-ón $\text{ipək}]$
 2SG PRS-feel good because woman PST1-kill snake
 ‘You are happy because the woman killed the snake.’
 b. *agándi ɔ gu-ɔbɔn bese $[\text{gagualga}$ ui m-ón $\text{ipək}]$
 woman 2SG PRS-feel good because 3SG PST1-kill snake
 Lit. ‘It is the woman that you are happy because she killed the snake.’
 (ii) a. begul bam ma-an $[\text{mɔ̀ndi}$ ui ma-nu-ɔn $\text{ipək}]$
 friends my PST1-see man 3SG PST1-PRT-kill snake
 ‘My friends saw the man who killed the snake.’
 b. *mɔ̀ndi begul am ma-nu-an $[\text{ui}$ m-ón $\text{ipək}]$
 man friends my PST1-PRT-see 3SG PST1-kill snake
 Lit. ‘The man that my friends saw who killed the snake.’

- ¹⁰ Our analysis is couched in terms of the classical approach to in situ constructions as involving LF (covert) movement (as in Huang, 1982). As pointed out by an anonymous reviewer, in situ focalisation could also be analysed in terms of agreement between the left peripheral focus probe and the element to be focalised, which would remain in situ. If this analysis is adopted, criterial freezing should be construed as also banning the possibility for an element in a criterial position to agree with a higher criterial probe (in representations akin to (33)). This interpretation has implications that go beyond the scope of the present paper, so we will not explore them here, and will continue to assume Huang’s classical analysis of in situ constructions. As for the cases of object focalisation, it should also be noticed that, according to Belletti (2001, 2004) and Cépeda and Cyrino (2020), focalised objects may also involve local syntactic movement in the low focus field in the vP periphery. If such an alternative can be worked out for object focalisation in Basaá and Mmaala (e.g., assuming that the low focus position is not morphologically marked), nothing would change for our analysis of subject focalisation.

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